

Newsweek, March 14

History Is Going, Going, Gone

STEVEN LEVY, NEWSWEEK'S Senior Editor, has always been writing technology articles with a twist. His expertise lies in tying in technology and culture, and how it impacts the common man. Here, once again, he is at his usual best...

ALMOST 30 years ago I came to possess a little piece of computer history. At the time, it seemed to me a fairly straightforward handwritten letter acknowledging my request to terminate an apartment lease, with instructions on how I could recover my security deposit. What I did not know then was that my landlord, a fellow with the unforgettable name of J. Presper Eckert, was a pioneer of the digital era, a co-inventor of one of the first operational electronic computers.



The idea that this note might qualify as a historical artifact dawned on me a couple of weeks ago as I examined the 254 lots in the "History of Cyberspace" collection auctioned at Christie's on February 23. The earliest items were from the brilliant minds of the pre-computer age such as Charles Babbage, the 19th-century visionary who designed a programmable machine known as the "the

Difference Engine." But the meat of the collection consisted of documents from the vacuum-tube cowboys who made the early giant computers, especially my landlord Pres Eckert. His key papers were up for grabs, including the first business plan ever written for a computer company. Other items included his badge for that company (which became Sperry Rand UNIVAC), and his letters, though none concerning an apartment building on the Wayne Avenue in Philadelphia.

Jeremy Norman, the California bookseller who built the collection, was thrilled that the auction garnered unprecedented advance publicity. But on the morning of the auction, he seemed nervous that the big money might not show up. Indeed, a disappointed Norman afterward conceded that the results were "mixed." Though some of the most desirable items, such as a letter from Lady Ada Lovelace, who wrote the first programmes for Babbage's never-built machine (she was also Lord Byron's daughter), went for prices in the high five figures, barely half the lots were actually sold.

Specifically, the auction lacked spirited bidding wars between moguls who made billions in computers and cyberspace. The only PC legend in attendance seemed to be Lotus founder and venture capitalist Mitch Kapor. If Bill Gates (who once paid \$30 million (Rs. 1,305,750,000) for a Leonardo da Vinci codex) or Larry Ellison had been taking him on, we might have seen some fireworks.

Want to read more? Visit http://snipurl.com/digit_history

Wired, March 2005

The Fox Is Lurking

WIRED REPORTER REGINA Lynn writes how the Internet has changed our concepts of dating, love, and even sexuality. And that, she says, may not necessarily be a bad thing.

REMEMBER the days when hooking up with romantic partners online was considered weird? Something only geeks or losers did?

Even three years ago when I had an online dating profile, people thought it was strange that anyone would try falling in love "with a computer". Three years before that, when I flew across the country to meet a chat buddy in person, all the media could talk about was how dangerous it was to get involved romantically (or sexually) online.

Meet in a public place! the magazines screamed. Don't trust anything! Your intuition could get you killed!

Meanwhile, thousands of people less wired than I were

quietly finding companionship and sex through the connections they made online. It wasn't just the nerds. It was people fed up with the singles scene, people unhappy with their current relationships, people seeking escape into the drama of a romance novel or a porn film come to life.

And it was people finding the loves of their lives.

These days, if you're single and have Internet access, you're about as likely to have an online personal as

not. I even know a woman who checked her Yahoo! matches from a computer at the library for months. She saw no reason that the theft of her laptop should dampen her chances of meeting Mr. Right, or at least Mr. Friday Night.

Not long ago I read a series of articles about how membership in online dating sites was leveling off. Of course it is! If a matchmaking site is any good, it stands to reason that people would pair off and cancel their memberships. If the site isn't good, members will move on to places where they have more luck.

Besides, even if you count the marrieds pretending to be single, there are only so many daters in the world.

And dating sites are hardly the only place to find partners online. It seems that despite the mass adoption of database dating, the more traditional ways of falling in love online are just as popular as ever. Community and common interests are just as important as a catalog.

Last year, Janet Lever, a sociologist at California State University at Los Angeles, conducted a survey on cybersex and romance. "(We found that) a lot of people used the dating sites who never wanted to meet anyone," she says. "Women especially had to learn how to distinguish between guys looking for flirty and dirty talk from the men who wanted to meet. And it turns out that an almost equal number of people met someone through erotic chat rooms."

Visit http://snipurl.com/digit_date for the complete picture

